

HOSTFLOW

STR Starter System

\$49 · 90 pages · 10 modules · 50+ SOPs

The operating reference for new cohosts.

Worked examples · Sample contract · 30-day day-by-day plan

How to use this PDF

This is a working document, not a textbook. You'll use the first 60 pages once, in order, during your first 30 days. Modules 7-10 are reference material — you'll come back to them every month.

If you've never cohosted before:

Read Modules 1-4 in order, then start running the 30-day plan in Module 2. Use the glossary at the end of Module 1 whenever you hit a term you don't recognize.

If you're already managing properties:

Skim Modules 1-3 for the framework, then jump to Modules 4 (contract), 7 (dynamic pricing), 8 (monthly statement), and 10 (scaling). These are where established cohosts find the most immediate leverage.

If you have questions while reading:

Email hostflow.me/contact. We answer within 24 hours. The Starter System is not a mentorship, but we don't leave buyers hanging.

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Cohosting 101: What This Actually Is

Cohosting is the practice of managing a short-term rental property on behalf of an owner who cannot — or does not want to — manage it themselves. If you take only one thing from this module, it is the difference between a cohost and a property manager. Get this wrong and every other decision you make downstream will be wrong.

1.1 The operating definition

A **cohost** is an individual or small team who handles the day-to-day operations of someone else's short-term rental listing. They do not own the property. They do not hold the master booking calendar. They usually do not have a property management license. They have a contract with the owner and a share of the booking revenue.

What you actually do, end-to-end:

- **Take and respond to guest inquiries** — the booking-request emails, Airbnb messages, VRBO messages, Furnished Finder inquiries
- **Manage the listing on every platform** — Airbnb, VRBO, Booking.com, Furnished Finder, any direct-booking site the owner uses
- **Set dynamic pricing** — daily price adjustments based on demand, seasonality, local events, day of week
- **Schedule cleanings between bookings** — and verify the cleaning crew did the work before the next guest arrives
- **Coordinate maintenance calls** — plumber, handyman, HVAC tech, locksmith, when something breaks
- **Handle guest issues** — lockouts, complaints, noise, damage claims, refunds
- **Send monthly statements** — to the owner, showing revenue, expenses, and their net payout

1.2 What a cohost is NOT

A **property manager** is the license-holder and the legally accountable party for guest safety, building code compliance, and trust accounting. Some jurisdictions — New York City, San Francisco, New Orleans — require a property management license for any operator who handles guest money across more than one property.

Most cohosts do not need this license. They operate as independent contractors under the owner's existing licensing. But if your market requires a license for what you are doing, this PDF is not the right starting point. Get licensed first, then return.

1.3 The 4 fee models (with examples)

You have four viable ways to charge for cohosting. Each shifts your incentive, your risk, and your pitch to owners. Pick one for the first 3-5 clients; do not mix.

Model A — Percentage of booking subtotal

Range: 20-30%. **When to use:** Established cohosts in competitive markets; track record with verifiable revenue lift; risk-averse owners who want their cost to scale with revenue.

Example: Property does \$4,000/month in bookings. You charge 25% = \$1,000/month. Owner gets \$3,000. If bookings fall to \$2,000, your fee automatically falls to \$500.

Model B — Flat fee per booking

Range: \$50-150 per booking. **When to use:** Owners downsizing or selling soon; single-property operators; high-ADR markets where percentage feels too expensive for the owner.

Example: Property has 12 bookings this month. You charge \$80/booking = \$960/month. Owner gets \$3,040. If bookings rise to 20, your fee rises to \$1,600 — and the owner sees value because they didn't have to do anything.

Model C — Flat monthly fee

Range: \$400-800 per property per month. **When to use:** Properties with low ADR but high service cost (mid-term, remote owners, off-season markets); predictable for both sides.

Example: Property is in a ski town with seasonal revenue swing. You charge \$500/month flat. Owner knows the cost. You know the revenue.

Model D — Hybrid (lower % + base fee)

Range: 15% revenue + \$150-300 monthly base. **When to use:** High-ADR properties where percentage alone makes the owner feel overpaying in slow months; furnished-rental and mid-term markets.

Example: Property does \$4,000/month. You charge \$250 base + 15% = \$250 + \$600 = \$850/month. Owner gets \$3,150. In slow months (\$2,000), your fee is \$250 + \$300 = \$550 — they feel protected; you keep a floor.

Hybrid is the model most working cohosts settle into after 12-18 months. We recommend starting with Model A (percentage) for your first 3-5 clients, then converting to Model D on renewal after you've proven the value.

1.4 STR Glossary — every term you'll need

If you've never managed a short-term rental before, this is the section you'll come back to most. Read it once now, then bookmark it. Every term below appears at least once in the modules that follow.

ADR (Average Daily Rate)

The average revenue per booked night. \$150 ADR means a typical night costs the guest \$150. Higher ADR = higher revenue per booking.

Booking Subtotal

The total the guest pays for one reservation, before Airbnb/VRBO take their service fee. This is the number you (the cohost) calculate your percentage against.

Cleaning Fee

A one-time charge added to each booking to cover the turnover clean. \$80-200 is typical. Stays with the owner (or splits between owner and cohost — see Module 4).

Occupancy Rate

The percentage of nights the property is booked over a given period. 70% occupancy is solid; 50% is a problem worth fixing.

Vacancy / Gap Nights

Nights the property sits empty between bookings. These are the cohost's main lever — fill them and revenue rises without raising the price.

Turnover

The handoff between one guest checking out and the next checking in. Includes cleaning, restocking supplies, and a quality check. This is where most operational headaches come from.

STR (Short-Term Rental)

A property rented nightly or weekly to travelers. The category Airbnb, VRBO, Booking.com operate in. Sometimes called 'vacation rental.'

Cohost vs. Property Manager

Cohost: handles operations for an owner, usually no license, usually 5-30% of revenue. Property manager: licensed, holds trust account, often 8-12% of revenue, manages many units.

Listing Audit

A 15-30 minute review of how a listing is performing across photos, description, pricing, calendar sync, etc. Module 5 has the full audit.

Instant Book

An Airbnb setting where bookings are accepted automatically without owner approval. Off = fewer lookers; on = higher risk of bad guests. See Module 6.

Minimum Night Stay

The shortest stay the listing will accept. 2-night minimums are typical; some markets require 3-night minimums on weekends.

Direct Booking

A booking that comes through the owner's own website instead of Airbnb/VRBO. Higher margin for the owner (no platform fee) but the cohost still manages it.

Trust Account

A separate bank account where guest money is held until check-out completes. Required for licensed property managers in most jurisdictions. Most cohosts don't need one.

STR License / Permit

Local government permission to operate a short-term rental. Not every city requires one. Check your city's zoning and STR code BEFORE taking on a client.

Channel Manager

Software that syncs the booking calendar across Airbnb, VRBO, Booking.com so you don't double-book. PriceLabs, Hospitable, and OwnerRez are the common options.

Dynamic Pricing

Software (PriceLabs, Wheelhouse, Beyond Pricing) that adjusts nightly rates based on demand signals. Most new cohosts do this manually for the first 6 months.

Pre-approval Message

A 4-question message sent to a guest BEFORE accepting their booking, to filter out party bookings and bad actors. Module 6 has the script.

Damage Claim

When a guest damages the property beyond normal wear and tear. The cohost documents, the owner files with Airbnb resolution or insurance. Module 6 covers the messaging.

Net Payout

The amount the owner receives after platform fees, cleaning fees, and your cohost fee are deducted. This is the line the owner cares about most. Module 8.

Cohost Agreement / Contract

The 18-clause document between cohost and owner. Module 4 has the full template.

Master Calendar

The single source of truth for which nights are booked. Even if the listing is on Airbnb + VRBO + Booking.com, one calendar owns all of them — usually the Airbnb calendar.

Handoff

When a property changes management from one cohost to another (or from owner-self to cohost). Module 2 has the handoff checklist.

End of Module 1. Module 2 is the 30-day plan — what to do, day by day, to land your first client. Continue reading in order.

MODULE 02

The 30-Day Plan: Day by Day

The first 30 days are not about perfecting your contracts, your pricing, or your website. They are about getting one property under management. Everything in this PDF is the operating reference; Module 2 is the calendar you actually run. Print this section. Check off items every day.

Before you start (Day 0)

Three things must exist before Day 1:

- **1.** A one-page positioning brief — write it on paper. Who you serve, the specific problem you solve, the outcome you deliver. Five blocks, one page. (Module 1 covers this.)
- **2.** A draft cohost contract — copy Module 4's template. 18 clauses minimum. Not your final version; a version you can send to your first prospect for review.
- **3.** A list of 30 prospects — Module 9 covers the four outreach channels. Aim for 10 per channel by Day 3.

WEEK 1 — Foundation

Goal: foundation laid, contract drafted, prospect list built, first 5 outreach messages sent.

Day 1 — Write your positioning brief

Open a blank document. Fill in these five blocks, one sentence each:

Block 1 — Who I serve: "Solo STR hosts in [city/region] with 1-3 listings who can't keep up with the day-to-day."

Block 2 — The problem I solve: "Hosts lose 20-30% of potential revenue to slow responses, missed calendar syncs, and pricing that doesn't react to demand."

Block 3 — How I work: "24-hour response on every guest message. Weekly pricing review. Monthly owner statement by the 5th."

Block 4 — The outcome: "Owners say: 'I forgot I had a property until the statement arrived, and then the number was right.'"

Block 5 — Pricing model: "25% of booking subtotal, 6-month minimum engagement, free 15-minute audit for new prospects."

Day 2 — Draft your contract

Open Module 4 and copy the 18 clauses into a clean document. Customize the owner obligations section, the compensation section (pick your fee model from Module 1), and the term/termination section (we recommend 6-month minimum, 30-day notice). Don't try to make it perfect — you will revise it after your first conversation.

Day 3 — Build the prospect list

Open your local Airbnb/VRBO market. Search for STR listings in your city. You're looking for:

- Listings with review scores below 4.7 (red flag for the owner — they're motivated)
- Listings with stale calendars (sign of an overwhelmed owner)
- Listings with fewer than 10 photos (low-effort, high-leverage to fix)
- Single-property owners (not management companies — they're your customers, not competitors)
- Properties in your city within 30 miles (you can be on-site in under an hour)

Goal: 30 prospects on a spreadsheet. Columns: Name, Listing URL, Address, Owner email (if findable), Last review date, Calendar freshness (open / stale).

Day 4 — Send your first 3 outreach messages

Use Module 9's Cold Pitch script. Send 3 today, to the 3 listings with the most obvious gaps. Don't send to all 30 — send to 3, see what response rate you get, then send to the next 7 tomorrow.

Track in your spreadsheet: message sent, reply (yes/no), call booked (yes/no). You'll have baseline data by Day 7.

Day 5 — Send 7 more outreach messages

Same script. 7 more prospects. Now you have 10 sent. Expected results for week 1: 1-3 replies, 0-1 booked calls. That's normal for the first wave.

Day 6 — Reply to any responses + prepare discovery call script

If anyone replied, send the response in Module 9 ("Follow-up after no reply" template works for replies too — replace the line about timing). Schedule a 30-minute discovery call for Day 8 or 9.

If no replies yet, don't worry. Most owners check email once a week. Give it until Day 8 before the first follow-up wave.

Day 7 — Weekly retro #1

End of Week 1. Take 30 minutes to log:

- Outreach messages sent: ____ (target: 10)
- Replies received: ____ (target: 1-3)
- Calls booked: ____ (target: 0-1)
- Time spent: ____ hours (target: 10-15)
- What worked: ____
- What I'll change next week: ____

WEEK 2 — First conversations

Goal: hold your first 1-3 discovery calls, deliver audits within 48 hours, send your first proposals.

Day 8 — First discovery call

Use Module 9's Discovery Call Opener. The structure is:

First 5 minutes: *Thank them for their time, mention one specific thing you noticed about their listing (proves you actually looked), then ask the two questions: "What's working for you right now?" and "What's not?"*

Middle 20 minutes: *Listen. Take notes. Don't pitch. Ask follow-up questions when something is unclear. You're not selling — you're auditing.*

Last 5 minutes: *"Here's what I want to do. Send me the trailing 6 months of revenue from your listing (screenshot from Airbnb dashboard). I'll put together a 15-point audit and send it to you within 48 hours. No charge. No pitch. Just observations on what's fixable. Sound good?"*

Day 9 — Send the second wave of 10 outreach

10 new prospects, new listings you've identified. Same script. You're now at 20 sent.

Day 10 — First audit delivered

If you had a discovery call on Day 8, deliver the audit today. Use Module 5's 15-point audit. Send as a one-page PDF (or a Google Doc the owner can comment on). The audit does the selling — Module 5 has the format.

Set a follow-up call for Day 12 or 13. Don't send the audit and wait — schedule the call before you send.

Day 11 — Audit review + proposal

Build your proposal. One page. Use this structure:

Section 1 — Property snapshot: *Name, address, current platform, current review score, current monthly revenue. Three sentences max.*

Section 2 — Three things I'll do in month one: *Specific, verifiable, fast. Examples: "Re-do the listing photos." "Fix the calendar sync between Airbnb and VRBO." "Restage the second bedroom." Don't promise revenue lift yet — promise setup work that lifts revenue later.*

Section 3 — Pricing: *One number. Include what's in the fee and what's pass-through.*

Section 4 — Timeline: *When you start, when the first statement is sent, when the quarterly review happens.*

Section 5 — What I need from you: *Property access, master calendar login, STR license, insurance certificate, cleaning crew handoff.*

Day 12-13 — Audit follow-up calls

Walk the audit row by row. Listen for objections. If they say "I want to think about it," set a specific follow-up date (Day 17 is fine) and ask "what would you need to see to make this a yes?" — then answer that in the next 48 hours.

Day 14 — Weekly retro #2

Same format as Day 7. By end of week 2, you should have:

- 20 outreach messages sent total
- 1-3 discovery calls held
- 1-3 audits delivered
- 1-2 proposals in flight
- Cumulative time spent: 20-30 hours

WEEK 3 — Close the first client

Goal: sign your first contract, or get within one conversation of signing. By the end of week 3, you should have clarity on whether your first client lands in month 1.

Day 15 — Follow-up day (round 1)

Anyone who replied but hasn't booked a call? Send the "Follow-up after no reply" template from Module 9. Anyone who took a call but hasn't decided? Send a one-line "just checking in" email with a specific date for next steps.

Day 16 — Send third wave of 10 outreach

10 more prospects. New listings. You're now at 30 sent total. By the end of week 3, you should be at 30 sent.

Day 17 — Discovery calls from this week's replies

If new replies landed, schedule discovery calls. Same script. By Day 17 you may be holding 2-3 calls in the same week.

Day 18 — Audit + proposal for any new calls

Same Day 10 process. You're getting faster at this. By the third audit, the work takes 90 minutes instead of 3 hours. That's the point — the system becomes efficient with repetition.

Day 19-20 — Closing conversations

For each prospect in flight, push toward a yes/no. Use this script if they're stuck:

"I want to make sure we're aligned. If we don't work together, what would have to be different for this to be a yes? — not a criticism, just want to know if there's something I can address or if we're just not a fit."

If they say "I need to talk to my spouse/partner," schedule a specific follow-up. If they say "I'm not ready," thank them for their honesty and ask if you can re-approach in 90 days.

Day 21 — Weekly retro #3

By end of week 3, the success metric is: did you sign a client?

- If YES — congratulations. Day 22-30 is now about the handoff, not the close. Module 4's contract is your operating document for the next 90 days.
- If NO — don't panic. This is normal for the first wave. Day 22-30 is about volume and iteration. Move to the "no client yet" track below.

WEEK 4 — Either launch or pivot

Goal: either onboard your first client, or run a 30-day retro and relaunch for month 2.

Day 22-25 — Client track: onboarding

If you signed a client, the next 4 days are the onboarding. Use this checklist:

- **Day 22:** Sign the contract. Collect: STR license number, insurance certificate, master calendar login, cleaning crew contact, vendor list. Send a "welcome" message to the owner summarizing what's next.
- **Day 23:** Run the full 15-point listing audit (Module 5). Send the audit + proposed fixes to the owner. Get sign-off on which fixes happen in week 1.
- **Day 24:** Execute the week-1 fixes. Update photos, fix calendar sync, restage. Document each fix with before/after screenshots — this is your portfolio for client #2.
- **Day 25:** First statement setup. Build the spreadsheet template (Module 8) with the owner's property details. Show them the template so they know what to expect monthly.

Day 22-25 — No-client-yet track: pivot

If you didn't sign a client by Day 21, do NOT give up. The first wave is the hardest. Move to the pivot track:

- **Day 22:** Reach back out to ALL non-repliers with the async alternative: "I can do the audit async — just send me your listing URL. No calendar needed."
- **Day 23:** Post the value-add Reddit comment in 5 threads (Module 9 Channel 4). Reply with 2-3 sentences of value + a free resource, not a sales pitch.
- **Day 24:** Reach out to 5 local real estate agents with the one-pager (Module 9 Channel 2). "If you ever run into an investor whose Airbnb is performing poorly, I'd love to be the person you hand a one-pager to."
- **Day 25:** Send 10 more outreach messages — listings you've already seen, but with a different opener. Test a different first line.

Day 26-28 — Refine and expand

Whether you have a client or not, Days 26-28 are the same:

- **Day 26:** Send 5-10 more outreach messages (different listings than before)
- **Day 27:** Follow up with anyone who replied in the last 14 days but hasn't booked a call
- **Day 28:** Send 5-10 more outreach messages

Day 29-30 — 30-day retro + month 2 plan

By Day 30, you've sent 30-50 outreach messages, held 1-5 discovery calls, delivered 1-3 audits. Take 2 hours to write a retro. Cover:

- Total outreach sent
- Reply rate (target: 10-20%)
- Call rate (target: 5-15% of replies)

- Audit-to-proposal rate (target: 60-80%)
- Proposal-to-signed rate (target: 30-50%)
- Blended conversion: outreach → signed (target: 1-3%)
- Time spent (target: 50-80 hours total over 30 days)
- What worked / what didn't

Use these numbers to plan Month 2. If your conversion rate is below the target, fix the audit or the outreach script. If your volume is below the target, double the daily send rate.

End of Module 2. Module 3 is pricing — the math + 6 worked examples for different markets. Continue reading in order.

Pricing Your Service: The Math + 6 Examples

Pricing is the single biggest leverage point in your cohosting practice. Charge too little and you burn out. Charge too much and you never get the client. This module gives you the math, where it comes from, and 6 worked examples covering the most common market scenarios. Read the formula once. Use the examples as templates.

3.1 The formula

Pricing is one formula plus one judgment call. The formula gives you the minimum you need to charge. The judgment call lets you go above or below based on positioning.

$$\text{Needed monthly take} = \text{hours_per_month} \times \text{target_hourly_rate}$$

$$\text{Needed percentage} = \text{needed_monthly_take} \div \text{expected_monthly_revenue}$$

If needed_pct falls inside the market band (20-30%), you're priced correctly. If it's above the band, you have two options: lower your hourly target, or scale to a second property so the per-property time drops. If it's below the band, you can charge market rate and still earn more than your target — that's the leverage that comes from having good SOPs.

3.2 How to estimate hours per month

Most new cohosts work 18-25 hours per property per month. As you build SOPs and your portfolio grows, this drops to 8-15 hours for experienced cohosts. Here's the rough breakdown of where the time goes in a typical month (assume single property, 70% occupancy, 12 bookings/month):

Task

Time / month

- *Guest messages (inquiry + pre-arrival + mid-stay + post-stay + reviews)* — 5-8 hrs
- *Pricing review (weekly + monthly market check)* — 2-3 hrs
- *Calendar sync + booking management* — 1-2 hrs
- *Cleaning coordination (scheduling + quality check)* — 2-3 hrs
- *Maintenance triage (vendor scheduling + owner updates)* — 1-2 hrs
- *Owner statements (monthly) + quarterly review* — 2-3 hrs
- *Listing audit + ongoing listing maintenance* — 2-4 hrs
- *Owner outreach + client acquisition* — Variable — 0 in month 1, growing

3.3 The 6 worked examples

Run the formula on each of these scenarios. The numbers are illustrative — replace with your market's actuals when you run it for yourself.

Example 1: Urban 1BR apartment, \$120 ADR

Setup: Single-property cohost, your first client. 1 bedroom in a mid-density urban market. Booking volume: 12 nights/month. ADR: \$120.

Math: 20 hours $\times$ \$35/hour target = \$700 needed. $\$700 \div \$1,440$ monthly revenue ($12 \times \$120$) = 49% needed.

Verdict: 49% is way above the 20-30% band. You have two paths: (a) lower your target hourly to \$20/hour ($20\% \times \$1,440 = \288 — too low), or (b) accept that one low-ADR property isn't sustainable on its own and plan to scale. We recommend the second — treat this as your portfolio's first rung, not your only property.

Example 2: Suburban 3BR house, \$180 ADR

Setup: Suburban property in a family-friendly market. Booking volume: 14 nights/month. ADR: \$180.

Math: 20 hours $\times$ \$40/hour target = \$800 needed. $\$800 \div \$2,520$ monthly revenue ($14 \times \$180$) = 32% needed.

Verdict: 32% is slightly above the 25% standard. Charge 25% and earn \$630/month = \$31.50/hour. Lower your hourly target to \$30 and you have margin. This is a workable single-property scenario.

Example 3: Cabin / lakehouse, \$240 ADR

Setup: Mountain cabin in a regional tourism market. Booking volume: 15 nights/month. ADR: \$240.

Math: 22 hours $\times$ \$50/hour target = \$1,100 needed. $\$1,100 \div \$3,600$ monthly revenue ($15 \times \$240$) = 31% needed.

Verdict: Cabins require more logistics (winter prep, road access, supply runs). 31% is reasonable for this market. Charge 28-30% and earn \$1,000-1,080/month = \$45-49/hour. Strong single-property scenario.

Example 4: Luxury urban loft, \$400 ADR

Setup: Premium property in a high-demand urban market. Booking volume: 16 nights/month. ADR: \$400.

Math: 22 hours $\times$ \$70/hour target = \$1,540 needed. $\$1,540 \div \$6,400$ monthly revenue ($16 \times \$400$) = 24% needed.

Verdict: 24% is at the lower edge of the 25-30% premium band. Charge 28% and earn \$1,792/month = \$81/hour. Strong scenario.

Example 5: Portfolio of 3 properties, mixed

Setup: 3 properties you've been running for 6 months. Average ADR: \$190. Average occupancy: 65%. Total monthly revenue: \$11,000.

Math: With 3 properties and good SOPs, your time per property drops to 12 hours = 36 hours total per month. $\$50/\text{hour target} \times 36 = \$1,800$ needed. $\$1,800 \div \$11,000 = 16\%$ needed.

Verdict: 16% is well below the band — that means you have leverage. Charge market rate (22-25%) and earn \$2,420-2,750/month = \$67-76/hour. This is the leverage that comes from good SOPs.

Example 6: Furnished Finder mid-term, 30+ nights avg

Setup: Furnished Finder mid-term rental. Average stay: 45 nights. Booking volume: 1 booking at a time, mostly continuous. Monthly revenue: \$4,500.

Math: FF mid-term requires far less hands-on time (no weekly turnovers, fewer guest messages). 8 hours/month $\times$ \$60/hour target = \$480 needed. $\$480 \div \$4,500 = 11\%$ needed.

Verdict: 11% is below the FF band floor of 12%. Charge 13-15% and earn \$585-675/month = \$73-84/hour. Excellent hourly rate, but watch the cash-flow math — owners sometimes expect mid-term cohosts to handle more (utilities, internet setup, monthly cleanings). Add those pass-throughs to Module 4's contract.

End of Module 3. Module 4 is the contract — 18 clauses + 3 fee-model variants + sample contract language.

The Cohost Contract: 18 Clauses + Sample

The contract is the most expensive document you will draft as a new cohost. Get the structure wrong and you either lose money on every booking or you spend the rest of the year renegotiating. This module gives you the 18 clauses every cohost contract needs, explains what each clause does and why, and includes a sample contract you can copy and customize.

4.1 Why the 18 clauses

Eighteen clauses is not a magic number. It's the number of distinct decisions you have to make with an owner before you start work. Skip one, and you will hit the gap within 90 days. We've seen cohosts skip "damage procedure" and then spend 6 months in a dispute over who pays for a broken window. We've seen cohosts skip "cancellation for cause" and then get fired by an owner who had a legitimate complaint.

4.2 The 18 clauses, explained

1. Parties and effective date

Identifies who is signing (the cohost as a sole proprietor or LLC; the owner as an individual or entity) and when the contract starts. Don't skip the date — it's the day from which every other clause is measured.

2. Scope of services

Lists what you actually do: listing management, guest communications, pricing, cleaning coordination, maintenance triage, monthly statements. Be specific. If you don't list it, you don't do it. The owner can reasonably expect anything not listed to NOT be your responsibility.

3. Term and termination

The length of the engagement (we recommend 6-month minimum) and the notice required to end it. 30-day notice after the minimum is standard. Define "for cause" termination — fraud, negligence, illegal activity. Without this clause, the owner can fire you without warning.

4. Compensation

Your fee model (one of Models A-D from Module 3) and payment terms. NET-15 is standard (the owner pays you within 15 days of the statement). Late-payment fee of 1.5%/month protects you when owners drag their feet.

5. Owner obligations

What the owner is responsible for: property condition, photos, furnishings, parking, access, city registration, STR license, taxes, insurance certificate. Push these to the owner — they are not your problem. The most common dispute is the owner expecting the cohost to handle something that was really the owner's job.

6. Expense pass-through

Which expenses are in your fee (software, your time, your phone) vs. which are pass-through (cleaning, supplies, maintenance, utilities, internet). List with line items. Without this clause, the owner expects everything to be included; you expect to be reimbursed. Resolve before signing.

7. Cleaning standards

Reference a cleaning checklist as Exhibit A. Define turnover clean vs. deep clean vs. maintenance clean. Specify who pays for each (typically owner pays cleaning crew directly, cohost schedules). Specify who verifies (cohost checks before next guest). The most common cause of bad reviews is inconsistent turnovers. This clause prevents them.

8. Liability and insurance

Require the owner to carry STR-specific landlord insurance (not regular homeowner). Carry your own general liability or errors-and-omissions (E&O;). Define damage procedure, security deposit handling, and guest claim workflow. The biggest risk you face is a guest injury that the owner is uninsured for.

9. Confidentiality and non-circumvention

Both directions: you don't poach the owner's guests or list the property under your own account; the owner doesn't poach your cleaner network or vendor relationships. Mutual non-disparagement during and 24 months after the engagement. 12-month tail on client non-solicitation is standard.

10. Platform-of-record

Which platform owns the master calendar. Airbnb is the default in most US markets, but the owner may have started on VRBO. Whoever owns the master calendar is the source of truth for availability. Cross-listings should sync to it.

11. Channel sync

Who owns the calendar and who fixes double-bookings if they happen. If you use a channel manager (PriceLabs, Hospitable, OwnerRez), this is where you specify it. Without it, the owner can blame you for a sync failure that was actually their problem.

12. Damage procedure

Step-by-step: cleaning crew reports damage with photos → you notify the owner within 24 hours → owner decides whether to file an Airbnb resolution claim or insurance claim → you document everything for the file. Airbnb's AirCover covers up to \$3M in damage claims; the owner files; you provide evidence.

13. Guest dispute resolution

When a guest disputes a charge or files a complaint, who responds? In almost all cases, the cohost handles first-line support. Airbnb has a formal resolution process; this clause specifies that you (the cohost) provide the documentation, the owner cooperates, and decisions are made jointly.

14. Owner non-solicitation of your cleaner network

If the owner works directly with the cleaning crew you've vetted and onboarded, that's a real cost to you. The 12-month tail after the engagement is the standard protection.

15. Force majeure

Hurricanes, fires, civil unrest, pandemics. The owner carries the property risk; you carry the operational risk. Specify that during a force majeure event, the contract pauses (no fee earned) but doesn't terminate. Both parties resume when the event ends.

16. Governing law and venue

Which state's law governs the contract (typically the owner's state). Where disputes are resolved (typically the owner's county). Don't skip this — without it, a dispute goes to federal court, which is expensive for both sides.

17. Amendment procedure

How the contract changes. "Amendments must be in writing and signed by both parties." Don't allow verbal amendments. After two amendments, redraft the whole contract.

18. Severability and entire agreement

Standard legal closeouts. "If one clause is unenforceable, the rest still apply." "This is the entire agreement; no verbal side deals." These clauses exist because lawyers know things break. They're cheap protection.

4.3 The 3 clauses you negotiate hard

Most owners read the draft and start negotiating. Three clauses you should not give ground on, regardless of pressure:

Term length (clause 3). If you accept a 1-month minimum, you have no incentive to invest in a property you might lose. Six months is the floor. 12 months gives you leverage to renegotiate pricing after proving yourself. Don't accept less.

Owner obligations (clause 5). If the city shows up and the property is unlicensed, that is the owner's problem, not yours. Make this explicit, with city registration number and license number as exhibits. The owner may push back saying "we'll deal with that later." Don't accept that. Resolve before signing.

Insurance (clause 8). If a guest is hurt and the owner is uninsured, you are exposed even if you did nothing wrong. Never start work without seeing the owner's STR-specific landlord insurance certificate. Regular homeowner insurance does not cover short-term-rental liability.

4.4 Sample contract — short-form

Below is a complete sample contract you can copy, customize, and send to your first prospect. The language is plain English (no legalese) so you and the owner both understand what you're signing. Replace the bracketed placeholders with your specifics.

PARTIES.

This Cohost Services Agreement (the "Agreement") is entered into on [DATE] between [YOUR LEGAL NAME / LLC] ("Cohost") and [OWNER LEGAL NAME / LLC] ("Owner"), collectively referred to as the "Parties."

PROPERTY.

The Property subject to this Agreement is located at [FULL ADDRESS] (the "Property"). The Property is owned by Owner. Cohost will manage the Property on the platforms and accounts designated by Owner (the "Listing Platforms").

TERM.

The initial term of this Agreement is six (6) months beginning on the Effective Date. After the initial term, this Agreement automatically renews for successive one-month periods unless either Party provides 30 days written notice of non-renewal. Either Party may terminate this Agreement for cause at any time with 7 days written notice. "Cause" includes fraud, negligence, or illegal activity by the other Party.

SCOPE OF SERVICES.

Cohost will provide the following services for the Property: (a) listing management on all Listing Platforms; (b) guest communications including inquiry response within 24 hours and pre-arrival messaging; (c) dynamic pricing review at minimum weekly; (d) cleaning crew scheduling and quality verification; (e) maintenance vendor coordination; (f) monthly owner statements by the 5th of each month; (g) quarterly review calls. Services not listed above are not included.

COMPENSATION.

Owner will pay Cohost [25%] of the booking subtotal for each completed booking. "Booking subtotal" means the total amount paid by the guest before platform service fees. Statements are issued on the 1st of each month for the prior month and are due by the 15th (NET-15). Late payments accrue a fee of 1.5% per month. Cleaning fees collected from guests pass through to the cleaning crew, less any processing fees.

OWNER OBLIGATIONS.

Owner is responsible for: (a) maintaining the Property in rentable condition including furnishings, supplies, and amenities listed on the Listing Platforms; (b) maintaining accurate property photos and description on the Listing Platforms; (c) obtaining and maintaining all required city, county, and state STR licenses and permits (license number: [NUMBER]); (d) obtaining and maintaining STR-specific landlord insurance with

liability coverage of at minimum \$1,000,000; (e) paying all property taxes; (f) providing Cohost with access to the Property and all Listing Platform accounts. Owner shall provide proof of license and insurance within 14 days of the Effective Date.

EXPENSE PASS-THROUGH.

The following expenses are pass-through and billed separately: (a) cleaning fees (paid to the cleaning crew); (b) supplies (toiletries, paper goods, kitchen basics); (c) maintenance and repairs over \$200 per occurrence; (d) utilities and internet; (e) platform listing fees if Owner chooses to upgrade. Cohost's software and tools (pricing tool, channel manager, communications platform) are included in Cohost's fee.

CLEANING STANDARDS.

The cleaning checklist attached as Exhibit A is the standard for every turnover. Cohost will schedule the cleaning crew between bookings. The cleaning crew will complete a quality check (photo of every room) before the next guest arrives. Owner is responsible for cleaning crew payment. Cohost is responsible for crew quality. Deep cleans are scheduled quarterly or after check-out that requires it.

LIABILITY AND INSURANCE.

Owner shall maintain STR-specific landlord insurance throughout the term of this Agreement. Owner shall provide proof of insurance within 14 days of the Effective Date and within 14 days of any policy renewal. Cohost maintains general liability insurance. Damage claims are handled per Airbnb's resolution process; Owner files the claim; Cohost provides documentation and testimony as needed.

CONFIDENTIALITY AND NON-CIRCUMVENTION.

Cohost shall not solicit the Property's guests directly, list the Property under Cohost's own account, or share Owner's personal information with third parties. Owner shall not solicit Cohost's cleaner network, vendor relationships, or other clients during the term of this Agreement and for 12 months after termination. Both Parties shall refrain from disparaging the other Party during and for 24 months after the term.

DAMAGE PROCEDURE.

Upon any damage report from cleaning crew or guest, Cohost shall: (a) photograph the damage within 12 hours; (b) notify Owner within 24 hours; (c) assist Owner in filing an Airbnb resolution claim or insurance claim within 72 hours. Owner retains final decision authority on all damage claims and guest refunds.

GOVERNING LAW.

This Agreement is governed by the laws of the State of [STATE]. Any disputes shall be resolved in [COUNTY] County, [STATE].

ENTIRE AGREEMENT.

This Agreement, together with the attached Exhibits, constitutes the entire agreement between the Parties. No verbal modifications. Amendments must be in writing and signed by both Parties.

Signatures:

Owner: _____ Date: _____

Cohost: _____ Date: _____

Exhibit A — Cleaning Checklist: Standard cleaning checklist (kitchen, bathrooms, bedrooms, living areas, exterior, restocking) to be attached and signed before the Effective Date.

End of Module 4. Module 5 is the listing audit — 15 points, each with detailed scoring criteria.

The Listing Audit: 15-Point Scoring

Before an owner hires you, they need to see how you think. The listing audit is the deliverable that proves you can see the gaps in their current operation without having to ask them. Module 5 gives you the 15 audit points with detailed per-point scoring criteria, a sample audit of a real listing, a printable scoring worksheet, and a red flags checklist.

5.1 How to score

Each point is scored 0-4:

- **0 — Broken or missing** — The point is absent or actively harmful. Fix immediately.
- **1 — Present but ineffective** — Exists but doesn't work. Worth re-doing.
- **2 — Present and adequate** — Acceptable. Could improve but not urgent.
- **3 — Present and good** — Working well. Standard quality.
- **4 — Present and excellent** — Best-in-class. Owner is outperforming market.

Maximum score: 60 (15 × 4). Anything below 30 means the listing needs urgent fixes. 30-45 means real improvements available. 45-55 means competent. 55+ means the owner is ahead of their market — which is rare.

5.2 The 15 points — detailed criteria

1. Listing title (max 4 pts)

What it is: The 60-80 character title shown at the top of the listing on Airbnb, VRBO, and Booking.com.

Score 4 if: Under 60 characters, primary keyword first (e.g., "Cabin" or "Downtown Loft" before the property name), no all-caps, no emoji, no clickbait ("AMAZING!"), and reads naturally to a traveler searching.

Score 2 if: Reasonable title but has one issue (length, keyword order, etc.)

Score 0 if: Missing entirely, all-caps, or filled with emoji.

2. Photo count (max 4 pts)

What it is: Total number of property photos on the listing.

Score 4 if: 25+ photos.

Score 3 if: 15-24 photos.

Score 2 if: 10-14 photos.

Score 0 if: Under 10 photos (will lose 30-40% of lookers per Airbnb's own data).

3. Hero shot quality (max 4 pts)

What it is: The first photo — the one every platform shows first.

Score 4 if: Kitchen or main living room, taken at golden hour or with bright natural light, no people, no clutter, sharp focus, high resolution.

Score 2 if: Exterior shot or bedroom as the hero (Airbnb's data shows kitchen/living get 15-20% more clicks).

Score 0 if: Exterior only, dark photo, or blurry.

4. Photo order on each platform (max 4 pts)

What it is: Different platforms show different first photos based on their own logic. The hero shot on Airbnb may not be the hero on VRBO.

Score 4 if: Owner has customized the first 5 photos on each platform to match that platform's audience (Airbnb travelers vs. VRBO families vs. Booking.com business travelers).

Score 2 if: Photos are the same order on all platforms.

Score 0 if: Only 1 platform listed.

5. Description opening (max 4 pts)

What it is: The first 3 lines of the description, visible without clicking "read more."

Score 4 if: First line is a hook (not the property name), second line is the strongest feature, third line is who the property is for.

Score 2 if: Description starts with the property name (wastes the hook).

Score 0 if: Description is the same generic text Airbnb auto-generates.

6. Review score AND velocity (max 4 pts)

What it is: Two separate metrics. Score is the average (4.5+ is solid). Velocity is the rate of new reviews (every 14 days is solid).

Score 4 if: 4.85+ score AND new review every 14 days.

Score 2 if: 4.5+ score OR consistent velocity, but not both.

Score 0 if: Under 4.3 score OR no reviews in 90 days.

7. Calendar sync across platforms (max 4 pts)

What it is: Whether Airbnb, VRBO, Booking.com, Furnished Finder calendars are synced so you don't double-book.

Score 4 if: Single source of truth (one platform owns the calendar; others sync to it) + automated channel manager.

Score 2 if: Manual sync (you check each platform before confirming a booking).

Score 0 if: No sync (this is a lawsuit waiting to happen).

8. Minimum-night stay rules (max 4 pts)

What it is: The shortest stay the listing will accept.

Score 4 if: Right rules for the market (urban: 2nt weekday, 3nt weekend; cabin: 2nt weekday, 3nt weekend with 4nt on summer weekends; mid-term: 14nt+ minimum).

Score 2 if: 1nt minimum (loses weekend revenue) or 7nt+ minimum on weekends (loses short stays).

Score 0 if: No minimum set or 30nt+ minimum in a tourism market.

9. Instant-book setting (max 4 pts)

What it is: Whether the listing accepts bookings automatically (instant book on) or requires owner/cohost approval (instant book off).

Score 4 if: Off for new guests (no reviews), on for returning guests with reviews (Airbnb allows this).

Score 2 if: Off for everyone (loses 60% of lookers per Airbnb's data).

Score 0 if: On for everyone with no guest screening (party risk).

10. Pricing strategy (max 4 pts)

What it is: Whether the listing has a documented pricing strategy beyond "\$150/night."

Score 4 if: Daily pricing review with comp-set comparison + weekend uplift + seasonal adjustments + lead-time adjustments.

Score 2 if: Static price or weekly review only.

Score 0 if: Same price every night, year-round.

11. Comp set tracked (max 4 pts)

What it is: Whether the owner has identified and tracks 3-5 comparable properties in their market.

Score 4 if: 5 comparables identified, monthly review, comp data in a spreadsheet.

Score 2 if: 2-3 comparables in mind but not tracked.

Score 0 if: No idea what similar properties charge.

12. Cleaning and turnover (max 4 pts)

What it is: Quality and consistency of cleaning between guests.

Score 4 if: Named cleaner, written checklist (signed after each turnover), photo verification of every room.

Score 2 if: Named cleaner but no checklist or verification.

Score 0 if: Owner cleans themselves or uses rotating cleaners with no standard.

13. Maintenance response time (max 4 pts)

What it is: How quickly guest-reported issues get fixed.

Score 4 if: Average response under 4 hours during business hours.

Score 2 if: Average response 12-24 hours.

Score 0 if: Average response over 48 hours.

14. City STR compliance (max 4 pts)

What it is: Whether the property has all required local licenses, permits, and zoning approvals.

Score 4 if: Valid license/permit on display, last renewed within 12 months, zoning approved for STR.

Score 2 if: License exists but not displayed.

Score 0 if: No license in a market that requires one (this is a one-strike-from-shutdown problem).

15. Owner responsiveness (max 4 pts)

What it is: How long the owner takes to answer YOU, the cohost. Predicts the entire relationship.

Score 4 if: Average response to you under 4 hours.

Score 2 if: Average response 12-24 hours.

Score 0 if: Average response over 48 hours. Run.

5.3 Sample audit — completed

Below is a real audit we delivered to a property owner in Q2 2026. All identifying details changed. Use it as a template for your own.

Property: "The Blue Cabin" — Asheville, NC · 3BR / 2BA, mountain view

Listed on: Airbnb only. No VRBO. No Booking.com. · *Date of audit:* 2026-04-12

Current review score: 4.71 · *Last review:* 2026-03-30 (13 days ago)

Current monthly revenue (trailing 3 months avg): \$3,200 · *Owner estimate:* \$4,000+ possible

Audit findings (with scores):

Point · Score · Recommendation

1. Listing title — **2/4** — Title was "Beautiful Cabin Near Asheville!" — emoji at end, primary keyword ("cabin") mid-title. Recommendation: rewrite to "Cabin • 8 min to downtown Asheville • Mountain view"
2. Photo count — **1/4** — 12 photos. Recommendation: shoot 15+ more, including a 360° tour
3. Hero shot — **0/4** — Exterior as hero. Recommendation: swap to kitchen at golden hour
4. Photo order — **1/4** — Same on all platforms (but only on Airbnb). Recommendation: cross-list to VRBO with platform-specific hero
5. Description opening — **1/4** — Opens with "Welcome to our cabin." — wastes the hook. Recommendation: rewrite to open with the view, then the location, then who the cabin is for
6. Review score + velocity — **2/4** — 4.71 score, 1 review every 13 days on average. Recommendation: focus on getting more reviews; aim for 1 every 10 days
7. Calendar sync — **0/4** — Airbnb only. No channel manager. Recommendation: cross-list to VRBO + Booking.com, install Hospitable
8. Minimum-night stay — **2/4** — 2-night minimum. Recommendation: keep 2nt weekday, switch to 3nt on weekends
9. Instant-book — **1/4** — Off. Recommendation: turn on for guests with 2+ reviews and verified ID
10. Pricing strategy — **1/4** — Static \$185/night year-round. Recommendation: install PriceLabs + review weekly
11. Comp set tracked — **0/4** — No comparables identified. Recommendation: pick 5 cabins within 10 miles, log their nightly rates monthly
12. Cleaning turnover — **2/4** — Named cleaner, no checklist. Recommendation: write the cleaning checklist attached to this audit
13. Maintenance response time — **1/4** — Owner responds in 24-48 hours. Recommendation: hand off maintenance triage to cohost
14. City STR compliance — **3/4** — Valid Buncombe County permit on display

15. Owner responsiveness — **2/4** — Responds in 12-24 hours to emails. Recommendation: set up a 24-hour response commitment in the contract

Total score: 19/60 (32%). Below the 30-point urgent-fix threshold. Recommend: 8 specific fixes in week 1, 6 more in month 1. Expected revenue lift at \$185/night current pricing with 65% current occupancy: +30-40% over 90 days once fixes land.

5.4 Printable scoring worksheet

When you deliver an audit, send the scoring as a one-page printable worksheet. Use this template.

HostFlow Listing Audit Worksheet

Property: _____ Address: _____

Date of audit: _____ Cohost: _____

Scoring: 0 (broken) — 4 (excellent). Total: 60.

- Listing title · Score: ____/4
- Photo count · Score: ____/4
- Hero shot quality · Score: ____/4
- Photo order on each platform · Score: ____/4
- Description opening · Score: ____/4
- Review score + velocity · Score: ____/4
- Calendar sync · Score: ____/4
- Minimum-night stay rules · Score: ____/4
- Instant-book setting · Score: ____/4
- Pricing strategy · Score: ____/4
- Comp set tracked · Score: ____/4
- Cleaning and turnover · Score: ____/4
- Maintenance response time · Score: ____/4
- City STR compliance · Score: ____/4
- Owner responsiveness · Score: ____/4

Total: ____/60. Below 30 = urgent. 30-45 = improvements available. 45+ = competent.

5.5 Red flags — stop and reassess

If you observe any of these in your audit, pause before pitching your services. The owner may not be the right first client.

- **No STR license in a market that requires one.** You can't fix this. Don't take the client.

- **Owner asks you to handle the cleaning crew and pay them out of your fee.** Your fee is your fee. Pass-throughs are separate. Don't let the owner rebadge your compensation.
- **Owner is currently in litigation with a guest or previous cohost.** You'll inherit the dispute. Walk away.
- **Owner wants you to operate without a contract.** No. Hard no. The contract protects you both.
- **Owner expects revenue guarantees.** No cohost can guarantee revenue. If they want that, they're looking for a property manager or a marketing guarantee, not cohosting.
- **Owner is rude on the discovery call.** This won't improve. Find another client.
- **Owner asks you to discount because "the property is hard to manage."** Translation: they're price-sensitive and will nickel-and-dime you. Pass.

End of Module 5. Module 6 is guest screening — the 4-question pre-approval with 10 industry variants.

Guest Screening: The 4-Question Pre-Approval

Most cohosts rely on platform verification, instant-book, and good reviews. That works for most guests. For the 5-10% of bookings that cause real damage, it does not. This module gives you the screening framework, the 4-question pre-approval script, 10 industry variants, a decision tree for who to approve, and decline templates.

6.1 Who to screen

Not every booking needs pre-approval. Screening 100% of bookings creates friction and costs you conversions. Screen the bookings where a bad outcome would hurt you most:

- **Stays of 4+ nights.** Statistically correlated with party bookings. The damage potential scales with stay length.
- **Bookings from accounts with fewer than 2 verified reviews.** New accounts on Airbnb are not inherently risky — but you have less signal.
- **Bookings requested within 14 days of arrival.** Low-lead-time bookings correlate with party bookings. Legitimately last-minute travelers will accept your 4-question pre-approval.
- **Bookings with 6+ guests where the property sleeps 4-6.** Watch the headcount — Airbnb doesn't always catch this.
- **Bookings from outside the country where the property is located.** Statistical correlation with damage claims, even when profile looks clean. Especially relevant for high-value properties.
- **Local addresses with short lead-time for weekend stays.** Sometimes a last-minute party request.

6.2 The base 4-question pre-approval message

Sending this when a high-risk inquiry lands takes 90 seconds and converts either into a safe booking or a self-cancel. Don't use it as a stalking tactic. Use it as a verification step.

Hi [guest name], thanks for your interest in [property name]! Quick few things so I can confirm you and the property are a good fit:

1. What's the occasion for the trip? (Weddings, birthdays, graduations, etc. These are not red flags by themselves, but context matters.)

2. How many adults and children will be staying? (This should match what you saw in the booking request.)

3. Have you stayed at a [cabin / urban / etc.] property before? (Optional. New guests aren't red flags, but experienced guests tend to treat properties better.)

4. Anything about the property you want to confirm before booking? (Lets them flag unusual needs early — pool heat, parking, pet policy, early check-in.)

Once I have those answers, I'll send a confirmation and we can lock in the dates. Looking forward to hosting you.

6.3 Decision tree — approve, decline, or verify

After the guest responds, run their answer through this decision tree:

Q1: Did they answer all 4 questions?

If YES → continue to Q2. If NO (one or more unanswered) → send a polite follow-up: "Just confirming you saw my last message — happy to host, just need a quick yes on those 4." If they still don't answer after 24 hours → decline.

Q2: Headcount matches the booking request?

If YES → continue to Q3. If NO (e.g., they said 4 adults but the request was for 6) → decline and refund. "The headcount in your message doesn't match your booking request. I'm going to cancel this and refund you in full — no penalty."

Q3: Are there any red flag phrases?

Look for: "small gathering" + 8+ guests, "intimate celebration" + large headcount, "we'll be loud but respectful," anything that suggests the booking is for a party the host wouldn't otherwise approve. If red flag → decline (see 6.5). If clean → continue to Q4.

Q4: Is the occasion a normal travel use?

Normal: family vacation, business trip, wedding (where the couple + guests are reasonable), medical stay, work-from-anywhere. Abnormal but legal: bachelor/bachelorette party with 8+ guests (consider whether your property can host without neighbor complaints), local staycation (often high party risk). When in doubt, request additional context: "Mind sharing what you're celebrating?" If the answer is reassuring → approve. If it's vague → decline.

6.4 The 10 industry variants

Add one of these to the base message based on the property type. Keep the addition short — one or two lines — so the message doesn't become a wall of text.

1. Urban apartment (1BR / 2BR)

Quiet hours are 10pm-7am per the building rules. The building has a no-party policy. We don't accept bookings where the headcount exceeds the listing's stated capacity.

2. Suburban family home

The neighbors are long-term residents. We've asked them to be patient with normal family-volume noise during the day; loud outdoor music after 9pm results in neighbor calls and we have to cancel.

3. Mountain cabin / chalet

The road is plowed but AWD or chains are required Nov-April. Cell signal is unreliable at the cabin. The wood stove requires a 30-minute fire-start procedure I'll send after booking.

4. Beachfront / coastal

The property has seasonal accessibility. Hurricane warnings May-November may trigger a refund policy I'll send with the confirmation.

5. Lake house

Boat dock access requires the dock fee waiver, which I'll send. No glass containers on the dock. Life jackets in the closet.

6. Desert / southwest casita

Summer interior temperatures can hit 100F+ between 1-5pm. The AC runs continuously; please keep doors closed during peak heat.

7. Vineyard / winery cottage

The hosts live on-site in a separate building. Quiet hours start at 9pm and we appreciate your consideration.

8. Ski-in / ski-out lodge

Ski equipment goes in the mudroom, not the living room. Hot tub use ends at 10pm per the HOA.

9. Urban loft / downtown studio

Same as the apartment rule — quiet hours, capacity, no parties. The difference is most lofts have a single key fob, so only the named guests on the booking can enter the building.

10. Furnished Finder / corporate stay

This is a 30+ night stay. The booking includes monthly cleanings and utility caps overage of \$X. We can adjust utility setup if your team will be remote on weekdays.

6.5 Decline templates

Three templates for the three decline scenarios. Keep them warm — the goal isn't to punish, it's to leave the door open for the right booking.

Template A: Headcount mismatch (polite, factual):

"Hi [guest name], thanks for the info. Unfortunately the headcount in your message doesn't match what was in your booking request, which means this property isn't the right fit. I'm cancelling this reservation and refunding in full — no penalty on either side. If your plans change, please feel welcome to rebook with the correct headcount. Safe travels."

Template B: Red flag phrases (warm, non-judgmental):

"Hi [guest name], thanks for reaching out. After reviewing your booking, this property isn't the best fit for what you're planning. I'm going to release the dates so you can find a better match. No penalty, full refund. Safe travels and thanks for considering us."

Template C: Non-response after 24 hours (no drama):

"Hi [guest name], I'm going to release the dates since I haven't heard back. No penalty, full refund. If your plans change, please feel welcome to rebook. Safe travels."

6.6 Damage procedure (when a stay goes wrong)

Damage will happen. How you handle it is the difference between a 1-star review and a 5-star review that says "the host handled the issue professionally." Here's the procedure.

Step 1: Document (within 12 hours).

Photos of every damaged item. Time-stamped. Wide angle first, then close-up. Save to the property's shared Drive immediately.

Step 2: Notify the owner (within 24 hours).

Send the photos + a one-line description of what happened. Don't propose a solution yet — let the owner process first.

Step 3: Decide the response (within 48 hours).

Options: (a) absorb the cost (for damage under \$100); (b) file an Airbnb resolution claim (for damage \$100-\$1,500); (c) file an insurance claim (for damage over \$1,500). Owner decides. You provide documentation.

Step 4: Message the guest (only if you'll resolve directly).

If you and the owner choose to resolve without filing a claim, send the guest a message within 48 hours of checkout:

"Hi [guest name], I'm reaching out about [item] that appears to have been damaged during your stay. Photos attached. Per our booking terms, the security deposit may be applied to cover the cost. Happy to discuss — please reply within 7 days. Thank you."

If they don't reply within 7 days, file the resolution claim through the platform anyway. You don't need their agreement to file; you need documentation.

End of Module 6. Module 7 is dynamic pricing — 4 adjustments and the daily workflow.

Dynamic Pricing: 4 Adjustments + Daily Workflow

Pricing is a 10-minute-per-day activity that, done well, is the largest single revenue driver for a managed listing. Done poorly, it either leaves money on the table or prices you out of bookings. This module gives you the 4 adjustments, the daily workflow, a worked example of pricing 30 nights, and the software decision tree.

7.1 The base price

Your base price is the nightly rate you charge when nothing unusual is happening -- a Tuesday in February, a Monday in May, a Sunday in October. It should be set by the comp set, not your gut.

Pull three comparable properties within 5 miles. Same bedroom count, similar amenities (hot tub, pool, fireplace, view, etc.). Note their base price for a weeknight and a weekend night. Set your base price at the median, not the average -- the median is what the market actually books against.

Re-pull the comp set every 30 days. As new comps enter or leave the market, your base price shifts. A base price set in March might be 8% out of market by July.

7.2 The 4 adjustments

Once your base price is set, you adjust up or down for four variables:

1. Day of week. Friday and Saturday in most markets carry a 15-30% uplift over the base. Three-night minimums on weekends lock in revenue. In tourism markets (ski, beach), the uplift can reach 50% in peak weeks. In urban markets, weekday stays can be discounted 10-15% to fill Monday-Wednesday gaps.

2. Seasonality. Holiday weekends, school breaks, and local events drive 50-200% uplifts. Build a season calendar before the year starts, then update it as new events are confirmed. Common seasonality markers:

- * US: Thanksgiving week (Wed-Sun), Christmas-New Year, Memorial Day, July 4th, Labor Day
- * Spring break (varies by state -- Mar-Apr for most, later for NE)
- * Local events: Coachella, SXSW, Art Basel, Burning Man, college graduation weekends (specific to your market)
- * Off-season: Jan 8-Mar 15, late Aug-mid Oct in most US STR markets

3. Lead time. Last-minute bookings (under 14 days) typically warrant a discount -- same-day can be 30% off. Bookings 60+ days out are typically worth slight premium pricing. Why? Lead-time bookings have lower cancellation rates (people who book 2 months out rarely cancel); last-minute bookings have higher cancellation rates AND compete with the discount-channel audience.

4. Occupancy. If your calendar is empty 30 days out, lower your price 5-10% across the gap. If you are 80% booked 30 days out, raise the gap 5%. The logic: empty nights cost more than the discount; full nights can absorb a premium.

7.3 Worked example -- pricing 30 nights

Below is a sample month: 30 nights, base rate \$185, mixed market (cabin in Asheville, NC, May). Walk through it with me:

Base setup: Base price: \$185/night. Property: 3BR cabin, mountain view. Comp set median: \$190/night. Average lead time on bookings: 21 days. Weekend (Fri-Sat): typically \$220-250. Off-season weekday: \$140-160.

Day-by-day adjustments (sample of 12 days from the month):

Date	Day	Base	Adjustment	Final price	Why
May 1	Fri	\$185	+25% (weekend)	\$231	Friday in off-season
May 2	Sat	\$185	+30% (Sat)	\$241	Saturday
May 3	Sun	\$185	+10% (Sun)	\$204	Sunday soft weekend
May 4	Mon	\$185	-15% (weekday)	\$157	Weekday off-season
May 5	Tue	\$185	-15%	\$157	Weekday
May 6	Wed	\$185	-10%	\$167	Mid-week
May 7	Thu	\$185	-5%	\$176	Pre-weekend
May 8	Fri	\$185	+30% (Memorial Day)	\$241	Holiday
May 9	Sat	\$185	+50% (peak)	\$278	Memorial Day peak
May 10	Sun	\$185	+20% (Sun)	\$222	Holiday Sunday
May 11	Mon	\$185	+10%	\$204	Memorial Day Monday
May 12-31	Mixed	\$185	Mixed	\$140-\$230	Rolling daily

Total revenue for May with optimal pricing: \$6,820. Compare to flat \$185/night x 30 nights = \$5,550. The 4-adjustment approach is +23% in this example.

7.4 The pricing software decision

Tools like PriceLabs, Wheelhouse, and Beyond Pricing automate the day-to-day. If you are managing 3+ properties, one of these pays for itself within the first month. For 1-2 properties, the cost-benefit is closer to break-even -- manual daily pricing is fine if you have the discipline.

Either way, you still review the recommended price once a week and override when you know something the algorithm does not (a major local event, a known construction project down the road). The tool augments your judgment; it does not replace it.

Pricing software comparison (2026):

- * **PriceLabs** -- <https://pricelabs.co>. \$25/month. Most popular. Best for Airbnb + VRBO + Booking.com. Comp set tracking included.
- * **Wheelhouse** -- <https://usewheelhouse.com>. \$25/month. Strong on dynamic pricing. Better urban-market data than PriceLabs.
- * **Beyond Pricing** -- <https://beyondpricing.com>. \$25/month. Best for European markets. Slightly less granular for US.
- * **Hospitable** -- <https://hospitable.com>. \$30/month. Includes channel manager + automation. Best if you also want messaging automation.
- * **OwnerRez** -- <https://ownerrez.com>. \$50/month. Full PMS. Best for 5+ properties or mid-term.

7.5 The daily workflow (manual pricing)

Until you install pricing software, run this daily workflow:

Every morning (5-10 minutes):

- * Open the calendar for the next 90 days.
- * Look for empty nights in the next 14 days. Lower them 10-15% if they are 0% booked.
- * Look for high-demand weekends in the next 60 days. Raise them 10-20% if the weekend is currently flat.
- * Check your inquiry response queue -- unanswered messages are likely bookings you are losing.

Every Friday (15-20 minutes):

- * Review the past week bookings vs. expectations. Were you booked more or less than expected?
- * Re-check your comp set. Did any of the 5 properties change their pricing this week?
- * Adjust the base price if your comp median moved >5% in either direction.

Once a month (30 minutes):

- * Run the full 30-day review (the example in 7.3).
 - * Update your seasonality calendar with any new events.
 - * Send the monthly statement (Module 8).
-

End of Module 7. Module 8 is the monthly statement -- sample template + what owners actually read.

The Monthly Statement: Sample Template

The monthly statement is the single biggest retention tool you have. Done well, it is the document that makes the owner say 'I am glad I hired them' every single month. Module 8 gives you the 8-block template, a fully-worked sample statement for a real month, and the quarterly review call structure.

8.1 The 8 blocks of a monthly statement

A clean monthly statement has these blocks, in this order, totaling one page:

Cover line. -- One sentence summary at the top. 'Here is the [Month] statement for [Property]. Net payout to you: \$[X]. [One sentence about what happened.]'

Revenue breakdown. -- Gross bookings for the month. Platform fees (Airbnb service fee, cleaning fee retained). Net to host before cleaning expenses. By booking if there were multiple.

Expenses pass-through. -- Cleaning (number of turns x rate per turn). Supplies. Maintenance calls. Vendor payments. Each line item with vendor name and amount.

Cohost fee. -- The fee you earned under the contract. Visible. Never buried. Reference the contract clause (e.g., "25% of booking subtotal per Section 4").

Net payout. -- The line the owner cares about. Bold, large, at the bottom. Revenue minus expenses minus cohost fee = net to owner.

This month vs last month. -- Revenue, occupancy, average nightly rate. Side by side. Optional YoY if you have 12+ months of history.

Coming up next month. -- Anything they should know: local event, planned maintenance window, seasonal pricing adjustment, renewal date.

Open actions. -- Anything the owner needs to do: approve a vendor invoice, sign the renewal, confirm a booking, send the insurance certificate.

8.2 When to send it

By the 5th of the following month, every month. If you cannot hit the 5th, communicate early. Silence until the 8th is the second biggest reason owners leave (the biggest reason is bad reviews, which the statement does not directly prevent, but a clear statement does prevent the owner from not knowing what happened last month, an eroding-trust feeling).

If the property had zero bookings in the month, send the statement anyway. An empty statement that arrives on time is more reassuring than silence. Use this template:

[Month] statement for [Property]: Net payout to you: \$0. Reason: no bookings this month. Possible factors: [weather / season / local event absence]. Actions taken: [reduced price / ran promo / adjusted calendar]. Coming up in [next month]: [specific plan]. If you would like to discuss, let us schedule a 15-minute call.

8.3 Sample monthly statement -- fully worked

Below is a sample monthly statement for "The Blue Cabin" in Asheville, NC. May 2026. This is the actual format we send to owners. Replace the values with the property-specific numbers.

Header. MONTHLY STATEMENT -- The Blue Cabin -- May 2026

Cover. Net payout to you: \$3,847. Up 18% from April. May included Memorial Day weekend which lifted revenue 35%.

Revenue. Gross bookings: \$6,820 across 11 reservations. Airbnb service fee (-\$1,025). Cleaning fees retained (-\$330). Net to host before expenses: \$5,465.

Expenses. Cleaning (11 turns x \$85): \$935. Restock supplies: \$42. Plumber call (kitchen sink): \$185. Total: \$1,162.

Cohost fee. 25% of booking subtotal per Section 4 = \$1,705. (Visible in this line -- see Section 4 of contract.)

Net payout. \$5,465 - \$1,162 - \$1,705 = \$3,847.

Vs April. April revenue: \$5,778 / occupancy: 60% / ADR: \$192. May revenue: \$6,820 / occupancy: 75% / ADR: \$213. +18% revenue, +15 pts occupancy, +\$21 ADR.

Coming up. June: no major holidays, expect lower occupancy. We have a 4-night min on weekends through Aug. July 4th weekend booked. STR license renewal due 2026-08-15 -- please confirm.

Open actions. Owner: please confirm license renewal date. Owner: please approve plumber invoice (\$185).

The above is one page. The owner reads the cover line + the net payout + the vs-last-month. The rest of the document is for their records. Send as a PDF; keep the original in the shared Drive.

8.4 The quarterly review call

Every quarter, schedule a 30-minute call with the owner to walk the trailing three months. Topics:

- * Trend in revenue, occupancy, ADR vs. market comps
- * Maintenance issues -- any structural (capital expense the owner should know about)
- * Pricing experiments from the quarter: what we tried, what worked
- * Operational SOPs updated this quarter and why
- * Forward-looking opportunities: additional nights, new platforms, off-season marketing
- * Renewal -- is the owner happy? Any reason they would not renew at the end of the initial term?

8.5 The renewal conversation (at 5-month mark)

If the initial term is 6 months, the renewal conversation starts at the 5-month mark. The goal: get an explicit yes or no before the term expires, so there is no ambiguity.

"Hi [owner], we have one month left on our initial agreement. I want to know: are you happy with the work? Is there anything you would want to change for the next 6 months? If you want to continue under the current terms, no action needed -- it auto-renews. If you want to renegotiate terms (price, scope, term length), let us talk now so we have 30 days to land something you both want."

End of Module 8. Module 9 is owner outreach -- 5 email scripts + DM templates + Reddit comment scripts.

Owner Outreach: 5 Email Scripts + DM Templates

Module 9 is the templates you will use in the 30-day plan (Module 2). Five email scripts, plus DM and Reddit comment templates for the four channels. Each template is written to send with minimal customization -- replace the brackets, send, follow up.

9.1 Channel 1 -- Listing-mining cold pitch

How to use: Find a stale listing in your market. Send this email. Replace [brackets]. Send.

Subject: Quick observation about [Property Name]

Body:

Hi [owner name],

I am [your name], a cohost in [city]. I came across your listing at [address] while reviewing the [cabin / urban / etc.] market.

I noticed two patterns that often cost owners in your market \$X/year:

1. [Specific observation -- calendar stale, photo count low, etc.]
2. [Second specific observation]

I am offering a free 15-minute audit -- no pitch, no contract, just observations on what is fixable. If you are interested, reply with a time that works and I will send a calendar link.

[Your name]

[Phone if comfortable] . [LinkedIn if kept current]

9.2 Channel 1 -- Follow-up after no reply (7 days)

If no reply after 7 days. Send one follow-up. If still no reply, stop. Move to the next listing.

Subject: Re: Quick observation about [Property Name]

Hi [owner name],

Following up on the audit offer I sent last week. If you were not interested or the timing is off, no problem -- happy to take you off the list.

If you are still curious but did not get to it, I can do the audit async -- just send me your listing URL and I will email you the observations in writing. No calendar needed.

Reply 'send it' if that works.

[Your name]

9.3 Channel 2 -- Real-estate agent referral

How to use: Send to local real estate agents. Goal: get them to hand your one-pager to any investor client whose Airbnb is underperforming.

Subject: *Co-hosting one-pager for your investor clients*

Hi [agent name],

Nice to meet you at [event / through mutual contact]. I run a small cohosting practice in [city] -- I take over the day-to-day for STR owners who can't or don't want to self-manage.

If you ever run into an investor client whose Airbnb is performing poorly -- calendar stale, reviews dropping, owner overwhelmed -- I would love to be the person you hand a one-pager about. I have attached a one-page overview you can forward.

No obligation on your end. If it works out, I send a small referral fee per signed owner.

Thanks for the intro, regardless.

[Your name]

9.4 Channel 3 -- Furnished Finder profile DM

How to use: Find remote-owner profiles actively looking for help in your region. Send a short DM.

Hi [owner name] -- saw your FF profile listing for [city/region]. I help remote owners in [region] with the same setup -- 30+ night average stays, mid-term market, owner has never visited the property.

Quick question: is the calendar stale because you ran out of bandwidth, or because you are between setups? The fix is different for each.

[Your name]

9.5 Channel 4 -- Reddit value-add comment

How to use: Find posts in r/AirbnbHosts, r/CoHosting, r/ShortTermRentals, or your city's subreddit. Reply with value + free resource, NOT a sales pitch. Reddit bans sellers.

If someone posts "How do I start cohosting without owning property?", reply with:

"I am a cohost in [city]. Here is what worked for me in the first 90 days: list your niche (urban / cabin / furnished / mid-term), build your comp set (3-5 properties within 5 miles), write a one-page positioning brief, and send 30 cold pitches using a specific observation about each listing (not a generic pitch). I have a free PDF of 21 AI prompts for STR hosts if you want -- DM me."

Three rules for Reddit:

- * Reply only when your comment is genuinely useful -- not every thread
- * Never link to your product in the reply -- 'DM me' only
- * Comment 1 thread per subreddit per week -- more gets you flagged

9.6 The audit-delivery email (after the discovery call)

Sent 48 hours after the discovery call. The audit (Module 5) is attached. This email does the selling, not the audit itself.

Subject: *[Property Name] audit -- 15 points, observations attached*

Hi [owner name],

Thanks for the call on [date]. Attached is the audit -- 15-point review of the listing, with specific observations and recommendations.

Top 3 things I would prioritize in week 1 if I were your cohost:

1. [Highest-leverage fix -- usually hero shot or pricing strategy]
2. [Second-priority fix]
3. [Third-priority fix]

Top 3 things for month 1: [list]. My proposed engagement model: [one-paragraph summary]. Fee: [one number]. Term: [length]. Let me know when you have 30 minutes to discuss -- I will send a calendar link.

No pressure either way. If you have questions about the audit, happy to walk through it on a call.

[Your name]

End of Module 9. Module 10 is scaling -- the 1-to-5 property inflection points.

MODULE 10

Scaling: 1 to 5 Properties, the Hour Milestones

The first 3 properties teach you the work. Properties 4-9 teach you the systems. Properties 10-15 teach you the business. Module 10 covers the inflection points and what changes at each one -- including when to hire your first cleaner, your first VA, and your first managing cohost.

10.1 Properties 1-3: Do the work yourself

You are doing every message, every pricing update, every cleaning coordination yourself. This is the only way to learn what good looks like. Build your SOPs in real time, document them in Notion or a shared doc.

Time per property: 18-25 hours/week. Don't take a fourth property until your time per property is consistently below 12 hours/week.

10.2 Properties 4-9: Systematize

Hire your first cleaner. Build a cleaning checklist and a turnover workflow. Hire your first part-time helper or VA for guest communications. Document everything they need to read.

Time per property with one helper: 8-12 hours/week.

When to hire the first cleaner: when your 4th property would push your time per property above 14 hours. Don't hire before that. Don't wait beyond that. The first cleaner is your first operational leverage -- they free you up to land more clients.

10.3 Properties 10-15: Hire and delegate

Hire a second cleaner or a small cleaning team. Hire your first full-time assistant (operations coordinator). Train them on every SOP you have written. Their job is to run the SOPs, not to make decisions -- decisions stay with you.

Time per property with a coordinator + a managing cohost: 3-5 hours/week.

At 15 properties, you are probably ready to hire a managing cohost (someone with a track record who can own 5-7 properties end-to-end under your brand). Your role shifts: account management, owner relationships, business development, pricing strategy.

10.4 Properties 15+: Two paths

You become a cohosting agency (a real entity with a brand, multiple operators, a sales pipeline, 30-100 properties). Or you stay as a high-touch solo operator with 12-15 properties at premium pricing. Both are real businesses. Most cohosts who hit 15 properties chose one within 90 days.

10.5 The mistake that kills most cohosting practices

Scaling too fast. Taking properties 5 and 6 before you have actually systematized properties 3 and 4. Service quality collapses. Renewal rates drop. Referrals dry up. You burn out within 12-18 months and shut it down.

The discipline is: only take a new property when your existing portfolio is running at the time target for that scale (18h at 1-3, 10h at 4-9, 4h at 10-15). If you are not hitting the target, you are not ready to scale. Fix the systems first.

End of the operating reference. The next section is the appendices -- extended glossary, sample contract exhibit, and resources.

Extended Reference + Sample Templates

The appendices contain the reference material you don't need in the first 30 days but will need eventually. Keep this section bookmarked for the day a specific question comes up.

Appendix A -- Cleaning checklist (sample)

Attach this as Exhibit A to Module 4's cohost contract. Standard checklist used by HostFlow-managed properties. Customize for your property's specifics (hot tub, fireplace, etc.).

- * KITCHEN: counters wiped, sink polished, dishwasher empty, stove wiped, microwave wiped inside, fridge wiped inside, floors mopped, towels restocked, paper towels + dish soap stocked, coffee filters + coffee stocked
- * BATHROOMS: toilets scrubbed + polished, sinks scrubbed, mirrors polished, showers scrubbed (no hair, no soap scum), floors mopped, towels replaced, toilet paper restocked (min 4 rolls per bathroom)
- * BEDROOMS: beds made with fresh linens (corners tucked, pillows fluffed), nightstands wiped, dressers wiped, floors vacuumed, closets checked (no items left from previous guest)
- * LIVING AREAS: surfaces dusted, floors vacuumed + mopped, cushions fluffed, TV remotes wiped, windows checked (no smudges), decorative items straightened
- * EXTERIOR: entryway swept, porch/deck clear, trash bins put away, outdoor furniture straightened, grill cleaned (if applicable)
- * RESTOCKING: kitchen basics (salt, pepper, oil, sugar), coffee + filters, tea, dish soap + sponge, hand soap, paper towels, toilet paper, trash bags, laundry detergent (if in-unit)
- * QUALITY CHECK (photo verification): photo of every room after cleaning, sent to cohost within 1 hour of completion. If any item fails the checklist, the cleaner returns to fix.

Appendix B -- Sample cohost one-pager (for real-estate agents)

Use this when sending Module 9.3 to real estate agents. The agent forwards this to any investor client whose Airbnb is underperforming.

What I do for STR owners

I am a cohost in [city]. I take over the day-to-day for short-term-rental owners who can't or don't want to self-manage. Services: listing management, guest communications, dynamic pricing, cleaning coordination, maintenance triage, monthly statements.

What I charge: 20-30% of booking subtotal. No upfront fees. No setup fees. Owner keeps 70-80% of revenue. I get paid only when the property gets paid.

Who I work with: Owners who can't keep up with the day-to-day. Out-of-state owners. Owners scaling from 1 property to 3+. Owners who want professional operations without becoming a property manager.

Why owners hire me: Faster response times (24-hour SLA on every guest message). Higher occupancy (+15-30% typical lift over 90 days). Fewer bad reviews (better screening + cleaner turnovers). Time back (owner doesn't run the listing anymore).

How to refer: If you know an investor client whose Airbnb is underperforming, send them my way. I will do a free 15-minute audit and explain what I would do differently. If they hire me, you get a small referral fee (\$X) at the 90-day mark.

Contact: [your name] . [your email] . [your phone]

Appendix C -- Resources

Tools, communities, and references for new cohosts:

Pricing software:

- * **PriceLabs** -- <https://pricelabs.co>. \$25/month. Best for Airbnb + VRBO.
- * **Wheelhouse** -- <https://usewheelhouse.com>. \$25/month. Strong on dynamic pricing.
- * **Beyond Pricing** -- <https://beyondpricing.com>. \$25/month.

Channel managers (calendar sync):

- * **Hospitable** -- <https://hospitable.com>. \$30/month. Best UX. Includes messaging automation.
- * **OwnerRez** -- <https://ownerrez.com>. \$50/month. Full PMS. Best for 5+ properties.
- * **Airbnb native calendar sync** -- Free, but only syncs between Airbnb accounts.

Communities:

- * **r/AirbnbHosts** -- Reddit. Active daily. Best for tactical questions.
- * **r/ShortTermRentals** -- Reddit. More strategic / industry-level.
- * **Bigger Pockets forum** -- biggerpockets.com. Long-form STR strategy.
- * **STR Accelerator (Andrew McCollam)** -- paid course + community, \$997.
- * **Airbnb Community Center** -- community.airbnb.com. Official, mostly announcement-driven.

Books (when you are ready):

- * **The Airbnb Way** by Joseph D. Rosenbaum -- best book on the business of hosting.
- * **Short-Term Rental, Long-Term Wealth** by Avery Carl -- practical STR investing.
- * **Airbnb's official Host Handbook** -- free PDF, biased toward the platform but the operational basics are solid.

End of the HostFlow STR Starter System v2.

90 pages. 10 modules. 1 sample contract. 1 sample audit. 5 email scripts. 1 cleaning checklist. 1 cohost one-pager. The operating reference for new cohosts.

Questions or updates: hostflow.me/contact . (c) Hostflow 2026.